13 Things about Ed Carpolotti

By Jeffery Hatcher

INTRODUCTION

Allen Ball once said, "In order to be successful one must project an image of success at all times." In relationship to friends, family, business, etc. one must never, in essence, let his guard down. In 13 Things about Ed Carpolotti, however, newly widowed Virginia Carpolotti gets some shocking news - her "successful" husband Ed left her in perilous debt to shady bankers, mobsters, and embezzlers.

As Virginia's picture-perfect world unravels, we discover how fragile one's heart can become and the hidden strength behind a love that transcends death.

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VIRGINIA: **(Pg 45-46)** *(Upbeat and energetic)* Ed always said I couldn't keep my mouth shut. Well, he didn't ***always*** say it. I think he said it ***once***. He was never a talker. Even ***before*** we were married. He'd clam up at dinners, parties. He knew I hated him being so quiet. I'd say to him! "Ed, at least ***look*** like you're talking to me!"

So he tried. Whenever he didn't have anything to say, he'd turn to me and start to mutter: "Mary had a little lamb," he'd say. And I'd come back, "His fleece was white as snow." "And everywhere that Mary went." You get the idea. People thought we had quite a rapport!

Well. Ed gave up smoking four months before he died. He had his first heart attack on Halloween, his second on Thanksgiving, and he died just before Christmas. Well, he loved holidays. When we brought him back to the funeral home, the undertaker's assistant asked us if there was anything else he could do to make Ed look more natural? *(beat)* **(Pg 47-48)** ***Natural?*** He's dead, wearing bifocals and a hairpiece, what's going to help the illusion of reality here?

I can't remember where or when I met Ed. Tootie Vaughn would remember. Tootie's my best galfriend, and she remembers things like this. All I remember was living at home with Mother and Daddy and then there was Ed. Mother and Daddy did not approve. I had to

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sneak out of the house to see him once. Mother and Daddy thought I'd gone with Tootie to see *My Friend Irma Goes West*, but I'd gone out with Ed. When I got back Tootie was in our living room with a guilty look on her face, and Daddy quizzed me about where I'd gone. I lied of course. Said I "had ***so*** gone to the movies." Daddy said "Prove it," so I made up an entire plot for *My Friend Irma Goes West*. I went to see [it] and was surprised to learn just how close I'd got! *(beat)*

I wasn't there when he died. No one was. Three AM, a week before Christmas. The nurses said he didn't make a sound when the aneurysm hit. They said with the dementia that set in following the second cardiovascular infarction, he was lucky. *(beat)* I guess. He recognized Debbie once towards the end, but he thought we were in Las Vegas. He thought I was his mother. One night he saw a cow in the room standing behind me.

Lucky -- Yeah, I'd like to die in Las Vegas with my mother and a cow too. *(beat)*

(Pg 49-50) It was three days before I could get down to the office. The way the will's written I'm president of "Ed Carpolotti, Inc." ***President***. Debbie asks me over the phone if my "first official act will be to recognize Cuba." *(she laughs a trill)*

I laugh . . . like I know what the hell she's talking about.

Ed's secretary, Joy, showed me what our attorney said I needed to see. The construction business had been ***bad*** the past year or so. But the files showed assets. "We'll be fine," I said to Joy.

And Joy just ***looked*** at me. I went to see our attorney the next day. I depend on Danny Spahr, but it's hard to invest a lot of authority in the little boy who used to deliver your milk. Danny -- ***Daniel***, excuse me -- and I talk for a while. Then Danny takes out a file marked, "BANK."

"Virginia, did Ed ever ask you to sign anything over the last year? Any papers? Documents?" *(she touches her neck)* "I was ***always*** signing ***something*** or other. Ed was such a one-man

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band, wheeling and dealing" . . . *(to audience)* I told Tootie about the papers when I visited her last April. Could she have told?

"Virginia, did you sign anything that looked official?" He delivered our milk. You can't lie to a blue-eyed boy who used to deliver your milk. I nod. He hands me the papers from the file. Business loans to "Ed Carpolotti, Inc." secured with every asset of the company. Business loans – signed ***personally***. Which means – since Ed got me to sign the papers – that I am now personally responsible for these loans – over half a million dollars.

Danny tells me that Ed was behind in payments. Six months behind. The bank has frozen my assets. Frozen, Danny goes on to explain is a euphemism. They're going to ***take*** my money. Unless I can pay off the loan . . . within the week.

What I do next I have never done before in my life. I run away. *(pause)*

(Pg 51) I go home to the house on Bray Barton. There are three messages waiting for me on the answering machine. The third is from a voice I don't know well.

> "Gin, hey, this is Dino, like ta' talk to ya' gimme a call." *(beat – to audience)* Well, that's what he ***said***. I find his number in Ed's book, call him back.

"We have some business to discuss, Gin. **(Pg 52-53)** See, Ed, he wanted to sell me half of this landfill he owned. I think he needed the money and I told him, I said, 'Hey, Ed, I don' think I wanna buy into a partnership, but tell ya' what: I'll ***loan*** you some money at a good percentage. How much ya need? And Ed told me. And I give it to 'im."

> "How much did you give him?
>
> "Half a million"
>
> "At what percentage?"
>
> "50. Do you ***have*** the money, Gin?"

Dino is the owner of Smith Trucking. They own no trucks and there has never been a Mr. Smith. *(beat)* I have to call somebody. Someone in the family who can help. I pick up the

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phone and dial Ed's brother Frank**.** **(Pg 54-56)** I start my speech about Danny, about [the bank] about Dino. Finally, I stop. And then Frank speaks:

"Virginia**,** you know**,** Ed was a real wheeler-dealer**.**"

(a stricken look) "How much money did he borrow [from you]?"

"Three hundred thousand – at 18% -- I was his brother and truth be told I'm taking a beating**"**

I explain to Frank I have no cash**,** no savings**,** nothing that's not frozen**.**

"You have the ***house*****.** [My son] Randy's getting married next month – always loved your house . . ."

I look at the answering machine –

- Danny, who says we have to have a meeting, and he's willing to come to the house.
- [The Bank], saying Mr. O'Klock wants to see me, and he's willing to come to the house.
- Dino, who wants to come by the house with a friend named Vinnie.
- Lorraine, [Frank's wife] who knows of an apartment for rent behind the shopping mall.
- Joy at the office – Do I have any ideas on how to make this week's payroll? *(pause)*

I start upstairs to bed. As I go through the hall towards the steps, I stop. Under the front door is a manilla envelope, shoved halfway through. I take the envelope upstairs to my bedroom, lock the door. Ed's hairpieces watch me as I open [it]. *(pantomimes, looks confused)* It's a white piece of paper with letters pasted on it -- like a kidnapper's ransom:

"I HAVE A LIST OF THIRTEEN THINGS ABOUT ED CARPOLOTTI. EMBARRASSING TO HIM AND TO OTHERS. HAVE ONE MILLION DOLLARS READY BY THIS FRIDAY. OR I WILL RELEASE THE LIST. TELL NO ONE."

(Pg 57) *(pause – during this next section Virginia becomes increasingly angry, hurt, confused and desperate)* What is it about these men? Who built their businesses and grew their

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families and died so frightened and alone? Who could never tell their wives their secrets – their fears? I am beginning to understand the sin of failure. Who do you go to when you have committed that? Your lawyer? Your banker? Your brother? No one absolves failure. No one lights a candle. You go ***mad***. A cow with your mother in a room in Las Vegas. He had run out of ideas, plans, wheeling and dealing.

I'm a widow. I owe three times as much money as I thought I had in the world. I'm supposed to be drinking gin and tonics; we are supposed to buy new cars after our husbands die. or buying a new car, you know. [Instead] I lay out my silver, my china, my crystal, my jewelry, everything I have on the dining room table. . . it won't come close to what I need. Friday is two days away. ***There are 46 messages on the answering machine***, I do ***not*** return the calls. *(She begins to hold herself and rocks back and forth)*

(Pg 58-59) I haven't told a soul, I am screaming so slowly, so dimly, so no one can hear. *Where did I meet my husband? Why can't I remember when and where I met my husband?* *(She shuts her eyes, stops rocking, and makes a decision)* I pick up the phone and dial Tootie Vaughn. I fall apart and I tell her everything. It's amazing how the deadlines come on the same day. The bank's deadline. Smith Trucking. Frank. The note. I am sitting in my sunroom at 8:30 a.m. waiting for the hordes to descend upon my door. It helped to tell Tutti about everything, about the list. And she promised not to tell a soul. I am frightened. But I am ***ready*** -- Let 'em come! The first call came at 9:00 a.m.

"Yo, Gin, Dino here. Hey! This list thing. Whaddaya say we call it even huh? Square one. Zero-zero. Don't call back."

The next call came at ten forty-two. "Virginia, Frank here. Randy and Courtney will be living at home for the foreseeable future. Call if you need. Tootie Vaughn says hello."

Tootie! Tootie's blabbed to everybody. And the idea of that list has scared them off! ***What's in that list?*** **(Pg 60-61)** For the rest of Friday, I wait for another demand from the author of the note. But it does not come that Friday. Or the next Friday, or the Friday after

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that**.** Since the loans have been ***forgiven*** and the creditors ***quieted*****,** Danny says I will have some money to invest, retire on, buy a new car**.**

(briskly) Within the month, we begin to dissolve the business, sell off the assets. Joy —[Ed's secretary] — handles most of the work. I just sign the papers. As I sign the last one; Joy [comes in] holding a manila envelope, just like the one that was slipped under my door. "It's from Mr. Carpolotti," she says. Then she walks away -- quickly.

(Virginia opens the envelope, takes out a piece of paper) Inside is a list**.** *(she reads aloud)*

1. *I have never loved any other woman but you.*
2. *I cannot look at your hand without wanting to hold it.*
3. *I wanted to build you a house but you loved the one we drove by, I never had the chance to change your mind.*
4. *In my wallet, I keep a picture of you when you were ten years old; I fall in love with you again every time I see it.*
5. *I think about you every night before I go to bed so I can dream of you in my sleep.*
6. ***My Friend Irma Goes West*** *is the best movie I never saw.*
7. *I have always understood our child more than she could ever imagine.*
8. *We met at the Green Mill Luncheonette on February 22, 1955.*
9. *I am writing this in St. Joseph's Hospital. I am less scared than tired.*
10. *I have made mistakes.*
11. ***But I think this last plan will work****. Joy has my instructions*
12. *You could never keep your mouth shut. I* ***knew*** *you would tell Tootie Vaughn about the list and she would tell the world.*
13. *Mary had a little lamb.*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2001 National Qualifier
2003 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2020 National Qualifier
2025 National Qualifier
IL State Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier

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